

REET 2021 SCAM

Gehlot's Acid Test

By Rohit Parihar

The fallout of the REET (Rajasthan Eligibility Entrance Test) scam—involving the leak of the question paper for an exam to select 31,000 teachers for state schools, conducted in September last year—has left the Ashok Gehlot government besieged. Last week, the investigation by Rajasthan Police's Special Operations Group (SOG) led to the arrest of some members of the Rajiv Gandhi Study Circle (RGSC), a Congress-backed think-tank of which Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot is chairman. One of Gehlot's close aides, Minister of State (MoS) for Technical Education and Ayurveda Subhash Garg, is the national coordinator of the RGSC.

The REET exam drew over 2.6 million applicants, of which 1.6 million sat for the paper on September 26, 2021. The scam came to light around the same time, with one early report involving the police finding out—on the day of the exam—that the paper had been leaked to persons in Kota by candidates in Sawai Madhopur in an attempt to cheat. What is more troubling are the many accusations of corruption at the very top—even in this particular incident, the kin of police officers were allegedly part of the scam. Since the investigation began, some 30 people have been arrested.

On January 20, more evidence of the scale of the operation came to light, when the SOG arrested several suspects, including a man named Bhajanlal Bishnoi, who was apprehended in Gujarat. Following the interrogations, Rajasthan Director General of Police M.L. Lather says, "It appears that the first deal to sell the question paper was for Rs 5 crore, after which a few hundred others were sold the paper for anything up to Rs 15 lakh." There are also suspicions that ministers and/ or leaders in the state PCC (Pradesh Congress Committee) facilitated the scam.

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Chief Minister Gehlot has been personally responding to the crisis, attempting to undo the reputational damage his government has suffered. He has stood by the arrests. "Nobody will be spared," he said. "I was once quoted in INDIA TODAY as saying that every mistake deserves a punishment. I stand by that when it comes to the REET paper leak also." On January 30, Gehlot also sacked D.P. Jaroli, the chairperson of the Rajasthan Board of Secondary Education, another member of the RGSC. Three other officials were suspended, even while the SOG racked up its arrest count to 36. The CM also set up a committee, headed by former High Court Justice V.K. Vyas, to improve the security of all exam-based